£10,000, the rest being taken by a broker, and litigation was still pending at the time of the Indian Mercantile Marine Committee's hearings in 1924.[13]

Therefore, there was no paucity of Indian entrepreneurs even in a hostile industrial climate. VOC himself was quite aware of earlier efforts and of their fate.[14] But what marked out VOC was his politics. Wearing Swadeshi politics on his sleeves, he waved the red rag to the raging bull. SSNCo ran the gauntlet by confronting both British mercantile interests *and* the Empire. While the efforts listed above were largely business efforts—not that this saved them from being crushed—Swadeshism was in SSNCo's DNA. It seemed as though the Swadeshi Company was propelled by patriotism and not steam.

Testing the Waters

As early as in June 1906, within months of the first Swadeshi voyages, there was talk of floating a limited liability company. A company with a share capital of Rs 5 lakh divided into 10,000 shares of Rs 50 each was mooted, and it was said, two merchants had already subscribed to 200 shares. *The Hindu* correspondent brimmed with optimism when he wrote that given the 'good deal of patriotism and Swadeshi spirit manifest at Tuticorin' it would not be long before the entire capital would be subscribed.[15]

What followed later is described briefly and in general terms in V.O. Chidambaram's verse autobiography. VOC, using his considerable persuasive skills, first roped in Haji Fakir Muhammed Sait, a local banker and merchant, to promote the company.[16] Once Sait invested one-fourth of the entire capital, the other traders too lined up to invest. VOC sent telegrams across the world about his need for a steamer, and as a result, succeeded in acquiring one and brought it to Colombo. But Sait developed cold feet on seeing that the venture was guzzling a lot of resources. Once again, it was left to VOC to convince him: Sait could easily recoup his investment once the company hit its stride. The autobiography is all too